

THE RITE ARCHITECT

MASONIC ONBOARDING, EDUCATION, MENTORSHIP & RITES ORIENTATION

A concise working charter for future conversations

Inform accurately. Guard the Gate. Teach deeply. Mentor impartially. Let the Brother choose freely. Put Truth and duty before fraternity.

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Utah-oriented working model with jurisdictional caveats

How to use this guide

This document is the standing conceptual structure for our conversations about Craft Lodge onboarding, Masonic education, mentorship, York Rite and Scottish Rite orientation, religious qualification, and ethical recruitment. It is intentionally concise. It records the working definitions and principles established in our discussions while preserving a strict distinction between documented history, jurisdiction-specific law or practice, common Masonic tradition, interpretation, and personal working rules.

When a claim depends on current law, ritual regulation, eligibility, timing, ballot procedure, appendant-body requirements, or governing-body policy, verify it with the current competent Masonic authority before presenting it as universal fact.

Non-negotiable conversational rules

- Do not fabricate ritual, passwords, signs, grips, modes of recognition, private ritual text, or confidential material.
- Do not present interpretation as etymology, tradition as law, or one jurisdiction's practice as universal Masonry.
- For Craft Lodge membership, educate and inform the public; do not ask or invite an uninterested man to join.
- Distinguish Gatekeeping from Guarding the Gate. Masonry guards legitimate qualifications; it does not create arbitrary barriers.
- Treat the man's journey as mutual discernment: the man evaluates Masonry while the Lodge evaluates fitness and qualification.
- Teach for understanding, not mere recitation. Catechism should lead to proficiency; proficiency is a milestone, not perfection.
- Begin broad Masonic orientation, including York Rite and Scottish Rite, during the Fellow Craft stage so later choices are informed.
- Mentors must present appropriate opportunities openly, earnestly, honestly, and without prejudice or body loyalty.
- Religious tolerance does not erase jurisdictional religious qualifications; nonsectarian does not mean atheistic or religiously indifferent.
- Brotherhood never authorizes dishonesty, perjury, obstruction, evidence suppression, breach of law, or violation of professional duty.
- When an organization or member falls outside the regularity/recognition framework, prefer the neutral descriptive language established in this guide unless a competent Masonic authority has made a more specific formal classification.
- Obedience is owed to lawfully constituted Masonic authority within its lawful sphere; error is corrected through lawful appeal. No Masonic order authorizes crime, fraud, perjury, obstruction, or violation of a higher moral, civil, or professional duty.

1. Working vocabulary and status progression

The preferred model is a progression from public non-interest, to self-generated desire, to lawful admission, to education, to competent participation, and finally to lifelong mentorship.

Term	Working definition	Operational meaning
Profane	The uninstructed public outside the Craft who has expressed no interest or desire to join.	Inform and educate only; never ask or invite him to join.
Inquirer	A person who asks questions but has not expressed a desire to join.	Answer honestly; no invitation or pressure.
Aspirant	A man who has expressed an interest or desire to join.	Begins mutual discernment and preliminary inquiry.
Petitioner	An Aspirant who requests and submits a petition/application for membership.	Membership is not guaranteed; formal investigation and ballot follow.
Elect	A Petitioner elected to receive the three Symbolic Craft Degrees.	Election authorizes the next stage; it is not initiation itself.
Candidate	An Elect or Mason currently being prepared to receive the next degree for which he is eligible.	A recurring transitional condition before EA, FC, and MM.
Entered Apprentice	A Candidate initiated in the Entered Apprentice Degree.	Learner within the Craft.
Fellow Craft	A Candidate passed to the Fellow Craft Degree.	Learner increasingly participating in the work and broader Masonic landscape.
Master Mason	A Candidate raised to the Sublime Degree of Master Mason.	Mature Craft status with continuing duties, study, and responsibility.
Catechism	Structured oral questions and answers	Instruction, recall, explanation, correction, and

Term	Working definition	Operational meaning
	summarizing the experience and lessons of a degree.	reflection.
Proficiency	A demonstrated state of sufficient advancement in the catechism and lessons of the degree.	Evidence of progress; not perfection or final mastery.
Member in Good Standing	Working definition: a Master Mason satisfactorily proficient in the three degrees who supports his Lodge and keeps dues current.	Exact legal meaning remains jurisdiction-specific.
Coach	A Member in Good Standing who teaches the degree catechism and develops understanding.	Degree-focused instruction.
Mentor	A Member in Good Standing who guides the Candidate/Brother through his broader Masonic and life journey.	Journey-focused guidance.
Mentored Masonic Journey	The lifelong stage after admission and formation.	Continued learning, service, leadership, fellowship, Rites opportunities, and eventually mentoring others.
Membership	The lawful institutional relationship by which a qualified Mason belongs to a Lodge or other Masonic body and holds the rights, privileges, duties, and responsibilities attached to that status.	Membership is a legal/Masonic status; belonging is the lived relational experience of being known, instructed, supported, involved, and responsible.
Regularity	The condition of satisfying the applicable standards by which a competent Masonic jurisdiction evaluates legitimate origin, practice, sovereignty, and territorial standing.	Regularity is a prerequisite for recognition, but is not the same thing as recognition.
Recognition	A sovereign Grand Lodge's formal acknowledgment of another Grand Lodge for purposes of fraternal relations or amity.	Recognition is jurisdiction-specific, bilateral or multilateral in effect, and may change; always check the current recognizing authority.
Constituted Authority	Authority lawfully created, chartered, elected, installed, appointed, or otherwise established under the governing Masonic law.	Obedience follows lawful office and jurisdiction, not personality, popularity, seniority, or decoration.
Obedience	The duty to respect and comply with lawful decisions, orders, regulations, and judgments of properly constituted Masonic authority.	Preserve order through obedience; seek correction through appeal; never use Masonry to justify unlawful or immoral conduct.

Etymological anchors

- Profane - Latin pro fano: outside/before the temple; in initiatory usage, outside the initiated body. Profane does not mean morally unworthy.
- Aspirant - Latin aspirare: to breathe toward; figuratively to strive or reach toward. The key idea is directed desire.
- Petitioner - Latin petere/petitio: to seek, aim at, ask, or request. Aspiration becomes a formal act.
- Elect - Latin eligere: to choose out. The individual seeks; the body selects.
- Candidate - Latin candidus/candidus: white, bright, shining; Roman office-seekers wore the toga candida.
- Enter - Latin intrare/intra: to go within. The threshold becomes an action.
- Apprentice - Old French aprentiz, ultimately linked to apprehendere: to take hold of or grasp. The entrant becomes a learner.
- Fellow - Old Norse felagi: a partner who shares in a common undertaking.
- Craft - Old English craeft: strength, skill, ability, art; disciplined power expressed as skilled work.
- Master - Latin magister: chief, teacher, director; mature proficiency joined to authority and responsibility.
- Mason - Historically a skilled worker and builder in stone; deeper etymology is uncertain and should not be overstated.

Lifecycle in one line: Outside -> Desire -> Request -> Selection -> Preparation -> Entrance -> Learning -> Proficiency -> Fellowship -> Mastery -> Lifelong formation.

2. Onboarding timeline: mutual discernment and formation

The supplied Ideal Onboarding Process uses time deliberately. Waiting is not administrative dead space: the Aspirant period is discernment time; the Petitioner period is due-diligence time; intervals between degrees are assimilation and instruction time.

Stage	Possible timeframe	Purpose
Profane / Inquirer	Indefinite	Public education only. No solicitation.
Aspirant	6-18 months	Preliminary investigation, digital-footprint review as lawfully appropriate, Membership Committee

Stage	Possible timeframe	Purpose
		point of contact, public/social interaction, mutual discernment.
Petitioner	About 2-4 months	Petition read; Worshipful Master assigns investigation committee; references/recommenders, background and personal interview; committee reports; ballot follows.
Rejected Petitioner	At least 6 months before re-petition in the supplied model	No entitlement to admission. Continue to treat the man civilly and fairly.
Candidate / Degrees	At least 2 weeks between degrees; up to about 14 months in the supplied onboarding model	Coach/Mentor assigned; degree, catechism, proficiency, advancement. Readiness should govern within lawful timing.
Post-MM / Good Standing	About 1 week after completion of the model's good-standing milestone	Mentor celebrates achievement and presents prepared petitions/opportunities for appropriate appendant bodies.
Mentored Masonic Journey	Lifetime	Education, service, fellowship, leadership, Rites, and eventually developing others.

Timing caution: Another supplied interview handout says that completing later degrees may generally take one to three years. Because the source materials differ, all timing must be treated as illustrative until checked against current Utah Grand Lodge law and current Lodge policy.

The Petitioner Period and the Personal Interview

The personal interview is both an investigation and an educational checkpoint. The Lodge asks whether the Petitioner is worthy, well qualified, properly informed, and acting freely; the Petitioner asks whether he fully understands the institution, its costs, expectations, limits, and effect on his life.

- The Secretary's preliminary role should be factual, discreet, organized, and as free as possible from personal bias.
- The Worshipful Master assigns a competent investigation committee and ensures lawful procedure.
- The Investigation Committee is neither a prosecution team nor a recruiting team. It investigates character, qualifications, references, residence, reputation, readiness, and required belief, then reports honestly.
- The interview should be conversational rather than adversarial. Submission of a petition creates no entitlement to election.
- The Petitioner must be truthful, cooperative, patient, available to references/investigators, and realistic about time, dues, family, study, and participation.

3. Guarding the Gate - not gatekeeping

Gatekeeping, in modern slang, means arbitrary or self-appointed restriction of access to a community, knowledge, or identity. That is not the intended Masonic concept.

Guarding the Gate means protecting legitimate standards so that those allowed to enter are worthy and well qualified, and are duly and properly prepared to enter or remain.

- Guarding the Gate applies established qualifications impartially; it does not invent personal requirements.
- It protects the Craft, the Lodge, and the Masonic family through due diligence.
- It must never become an excuse for favoritism, prejudice, elitism, or unnecessary barriers.
- Once a man has lawfully entered and is qualified for education or opportunity, the responsibility shifts from guarding admission to teaching, integrating, and guiding him.

4. Coach and Mentor: selection, teaching, and relationship

The Worshipful Master and Wardens should know the members well enough to match the Candidate with a Coach/Mentor whose temperament, interests, life goals, communication style, and Masonic goals are compatible. The ideal pairing should feel less like an assignment and more like the beginning of a cohesive friendship.

Coach standard

The Coach must know the authorized catechism and teach it well. The aim is not to parrot questions and answers, but to help the Candidate understand the material symbolically, historically, pragmatically, philosophically, morally, and spiritually - always distinguishing fact, interpretation, tradition, and jurisdictional rule.

Teaching archetypes used in this framework: Plato (questioning), Vitruvius (structure and applied art), Voltaire (examination), Mr. Rogers (dignity and patience), Mr. Wizard (demonstration), Bob Ross (calm skill-building), Walter Cronkite (clarity and trustworthiness), and LeVar Burton (curiosity and continued reading).

Religious literacy and chaplain-like impartiality

The Coach should possess broad religious literacy comparable in spirit to a military chaplain serving people of many faiths: capable of respectful conversation without proselytizing, without pretending to be clergy, and without substituting his theology for the Candidate's. If the Candidate is Sikh, for example, the Coach should help him consider Masonic moral and spiritual lessons in a way that strengthens rather than weakens his own faith, and refer theological questions to competent authorities in that tradition when appropriate.

- In tyled, closed formal Craft Lodge business meetings, the working rule is no sectarian religious, partisan political, or deliberately controversial debate; verify the exact current jurisdictional wording when needed.
- Outside those meetings, open and respectful discussions are encouraged as conversations, not contests or proselytizing debates.
- The Coach asks: 'Are you learning and understanding this degree?'
- The Mentor asks: 'What kind of Mason are you becoming, and what path is right for you?'
- One Brother may fill both functions, but the functions remain distinct.

The catechism is the curriculum; the Candidate is the student. The goal is not merely a man who can answer the questions, but a Mason who understands why the questions remain worth asking.

5. Religion, the Supreme Being, the Great Architect, and Light

Supreme Being

Working definition: the ultimate, highest, uncreated Divine Being - the Creator and sustaining source of existence, worthy of reverence and worship. The phrase is superlative: it should not be diluted to mean merely a force, institution, ancestor, lesser spiritual entity, social ideal, or anything a person considers 'bigger than himself.'

The working Masonic formulation used in these conversations is the Fatherhood of God, the Brotherhood of Man, and the immortality of the soul. The exact legal wording of religious qualifications must always be verified with the current governing jurisdiction.

Great Architect of the Universe (G.A.O.T.U.)

G.A.O.T.U. is a nonsectarian Masonic appellation for Deity expressed through the builder's art: God symbolically as Creator, Designer, Orderer, and Sustainer. It is not a separate Masonic god and not a substitute religion. Architect is the metaphor; the Supreme Being is the referent.

The Lodge supplies a common symbolic title. The Brother's faith supplies his theology.

Religious toleration and qualification

- Freemasonry is not a religion and does not claim salvation, sacraments, or a sectarian theology.
- Freemasonry should strengthen, not replace, a Brother's own faith and duty to God.
- Religious tolerance means qualified men are not rejected merely because of denomination or sect; it does not erase the religious qualifications imposed by the governing Grand Lodge.
- Sincere belief, not philosophical sophistication, is the relevant qualification. A man need not be able to defend Aquinas, Maimonides, Ibn Sina, Anselm, or any formal proof of God to possess faith.
- An avowed atheist cannot truthfully satisfy a jurisdictional requirement to believe in a Supreme Being.

Satanism / Luciferianism in this working model

Standing Utah-oriented working rule: Satanism and Luciferianism are treated as incompatible with the religious and harmony requirements of this framework. The clearest documented case is Church of Satan / LaVeyan Satanism, whose own FAQ explicitly describes its position as atheistic, denies supernatural deity, and treats the individual as the 'god' of the subjective universe. That position cannot satisfy a requirement of sincere belief in a Supreme Being.

For public factual claims about other Satanist, Luciferian, Setian, parody-religion, or mock-religion labels, do not rely on a label alone or attribute sweeping beliefs without evidence. Use authoritative descriptions of the group's doctrine, the petitioner's own sincere professed beliefs, and the current jurisdiction's actual requirements. The internal working rule may be firm; external claims must still be documented accurately.

Masonic Light is not Luciferian

Masonic Light is a symbol of truth, knowledge, moral understanding, spiritual illumination, and apprehension of Divine order. The Latin word lucifer historically means 'light-bearer' or 'morning star' and only later became a traditional proper name for Satan in much Christian usage. That linguistic history does not make Masonic Light Luciferian. In Christian theology, Jesus as the 'Light of the World' is a specifically Christian interpretation; in a nonsectarian Lodge, the symbol is taught while the Brother's faith interprets its theology.

6. The nine Sacred Duties / daily priorities

This hierarchy is a central working rule. The order matters because Freemasonry exists to help a man fulfill the duties above it, not to compete with them.

1. **God** - Treat God, as understood within the Brother's faith and consistent with Masonic qualification, as the Chief Good and first object of devotion and duty.
2. **Country** - Be loyal to the country in which one resides; be a quiet, peaceful citizen obedient to just laws and faithful to lawful civic duties.
3. **Community** - Lift and improve the community through responsible participation, service, and constructive citizenship.
4. **Neighbors** - Be civil, kind, courteous, helpful, quick to forgive, and slow to judge.
5. **Friends** - Be dependable, encouraging, loyal, honest, and present in meaningful ways.
6. **Family** - Be a good spouse, husband, father, brother, son, and relative; love, support, empathize, and remain present in trials and triumphs.
7. **Vocation** - Be industrious, competent, honest, trustworthy, and ethical in work; inspire confidence through integrity.
8. **Self** - Practice self-discipline and continual improvement of mind, body, heart, and soul, including healthy sleep, food, exercise, and habits.
9. **Fraternity** - Use Masonic fellowship, moral instruction, accountability, and peer association to become better than the man one was the day before - not better than other men.

A healthy Masonic journey strengthens the first eight priorities. A Mentor should sometimes tell a Brother to choose worship, family, health, work, or civic duty over a Masonic event.

All humanity possesses equal human dignity. Masonic Brotherhood creates particular reciprocal duties among Brothers, but 'more especially a Brother Mason' never means that non-Masons have lesser human worth.

7. Language of Membership

Masonic language should describe the actual act, status, and authority involved. The broad word 'join' is useful in casual speech, but it should not erase the distinctions among inquiry, petition, election, initiation, advancement, affiliation, good standing, suspension, demit, expulsion, degree, Order, rank, decoration, and honor.

Core membership verbs and distinctions

Word	Precise working use
Inquire	Ask for information without yet expressing a desire to join.
Aspire	Express a self-generated desire or interest in becoming a Mason.
Petition	Formally ask a Lodge or body for admission; the petition remains the man's own act.
Receive a petition	The Lodge accepts the petition for lawful processing; this is not election.
Investigate	Perform impartial due diligence concerning character, qualification, sincerity, and understanding.
Ballot / Elect	The lawful body decides whether the Petitioner is elected; eligibility and petition do not create entitlement.
Initiate	Use specifically for entrance into the Entered Apprentice Degree unless the governing ritual uses the word otherwise.
Pass	Use for advancement to the Degree of Fellow Craft.
Raise	Use for advancement to the Sublime Degree of Master Mason.
Advance / Receive / Exalt / Create / Constitute / Invest / Coronet / Bestow	Use the exact body-specific verb for the actual degree, Order, rank, decoration, or honor involved.
Affiliate	Become a member of another Lodge or body after lawful admission according to its governing law.
Demit / Demission	A formal severance or transfer of Lodge membership; exact effects and procedures are jurisdiction-specific.

Word	Precise working use
Suspend / Expel	Disciplinary statuses imposed under governing Masonic law; exact authority, downstream effects, appeal rights, and reinstatement rules must be verified in the controlling Code.

Membership is not entitlement

- Eligibility is not entitlement.
- Petition is not election.
- Election is not initiation.
- Initiation is not proficiency.
- Proficiency is not mastery.
- Master Mason status is not the end of Masonic development.
- Fees support the process and dues support the Lodge; neither purchases worthiness, election, advancement, friendship, or honor.
- Membership is an institutional relationship; belonging is created relationally through education, fellowship, service, responsibility, and time.

Never sell Masonic membership as a product. Present it as a voluntary, qualified, elected, initiated, educated, responsible, and sustained relationship with the Craft.

8. York Rite and Scottish Rite orientation

Education about the broader Masonic family should begin as soon as the Candidate has been passed to the Fellow Craft Degree. The purpose is not pressure or premature petitioning; it is to give him enough accurate information to reach a logical conclusion, make an informed decision, and exercise an educated choice once he becomes eligible.

- Fellow Craft stage: explain what the York Rite and Scottish Rite are, how they relate to the Symbolic Lodge, their broad themes, structures, prerequisites, time/cost commitments, fellowship, education, and service opportunities.
- Master Mason stage: help the Brother compare paths and consider his own interests, faith, goals, family, time, and finances.
- Eligibility / good-standing stage: present actionable opportunities, then let the Brother decide freely.
- Do not imply that either Rite is required to be a complete Master Mason.
- Do not disparage a body because the Mentor is not a member of it. Where the Mentor lacks firsthand knowledge, say so and make an introduction to a knowledgeable Brother or official source.

Precise language of membership, progression, titles, and governance

When precision matters, do not flatten the Masonic journey into 'joined,' 'got a degree,' or 'became a member.' Use the body-specific verbs, resulting statuses, styles of address, and governing relationships supplied in the working overview. These terms identify what actually occurred and the body in which it occurred. Exact forms remain subject to current jurisdictional law and ritual regulation.

Precision rule: Petitioned is not elected; elected is not initiated; initiated is not passed; passed is not raised; a degree is not automatically an Order, rank, decoration, or honor.

American Rite / York Rite working progression

Body	Precise action language	Resulting progression	Style	Government
Symbolic Lodge	Initiated an Entered Apprentice; Passed to the Degree of Fellow Craft; Raised to the Sublime Degree of Master Mason.	Entered Apprentice -> Fellow Craft -> Master Mason	Master Masons: Brother	Grand Lodge -> Lodge
Capitular Chapter	Advanced to Mark Master; Inducted into the Oriental Chair (Past Master Virtual); Received and Acknowledged a Most Excellent Master; Exalted to the Most Sublime Degree of Royal Arch.	Mark Master -> Past Master Virtual -> Most Excellent Master -> Royal Arch Mason	Royal Arch Masons: Companion	Grand Chapter -> Chapter; General Grand Chapter R.A.M. International is treated in the source as a voluntary association.
Cryptic Council	Received a Royal Master; Greeted a Select Master; a qualified Select Master may be introduced into the mysteries of Super Excellent Master.	Royal Master -> Select Master -> Super Excellent Master	Cryptic Masons: Companion	Grand Council -> Council; General Grand Council Cryptic Masons International is treated in the source as a voluntary association.
Chivalric Commandery	Created and Constituted a Knight of the Illustrious Order of the Red Cross; Admitted a Knight of the Order of St. Paul / Mediterranean Pass; Admitted a Knight of the Ancient Order of St. John of Jerusalem / Order of Malta; Created and Constituted a Knight of the	Red Cross -> Mediterranean Pass / St. Paul -> Malta -> Order of the Temple / Knight Templar	Knights Templar: Sir Knight	Grand Encampment, U.S.A. -> Grand Commandery -> Commandery

Body	Precise action language	Resulting progression	Style	Government
	Order of the Temple.			

Commandery qualification note: The supplied overview treats Commandery as both independent and part of the York Rite system, requires good standing in the prerequisite bodies, and describes a Christian declaration of faith. Verify current Grand Encampment and local Grand Commandery statutes before publishing exact eligibility language. The source also distinguishes the Mediterranean Pass as a passing degree rather than an Order.

Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite - Southern Jurisdiction working progression

Body / status	Range	Precise action language	Style	Key distinction
Lodge of Perfection	4°-14°	A Master Mason in Good Standing is Advanced to Perfect Master (4°), then Received and Elected a Perfect Elu (14°).	Brother	Venerable Master
Chapter of Rose Croix	15°-18°	A 14° Perfect Elu is Received and Constituted a Knight of the Eagle and Pelican / Knight Rose+Croix of the Order of Heredom (18°).	Use source-specific style context	Wise Master
Council of Kadosh	19°-30°	An 18° Knight Rose+Croix is Created, Received and Constituted a Knight Kadosh of the White and Black Eagle (30°).	Sir Knight in the supplied overview	Commander
Consistory	31°-32°	A 30° Knight Kadosh is Constituted a Disciple and Soldier of the Holy Doctrine, Anointed and Elevated a Master of the Royal Secret (32°).	32° Master of the Royal Secret: Brother	Master of Kadosh
Court of Honour	KCCH	A 32° Master of the Royal Secret may be Invested with the Rank, Honour, and Decoration of Knight Commander of the Court of Honour.	Honorable	Not a degree; invitational rank/decoration.
Supreme Council Honour	33° IGH	A qualified KCCH may be Coroneted an Inspector General Honorary of the Thirty-third Degree.	Illustrious	Honorary 33° conferred by the Supreme Council.
Grand Cross	33° GC	A 33° Inspector General Honorary may have the Grand Cross of the Court of Honour Bestowed and Received.	Illustrious	An honor, not another degree.

Use the correct body and presiding title

System	Constituent / operating body	Presiding title	Governing relationship
Symbolic Lodge	Lodge	Worshipful Master	Grand Lodge
Capitular Masonry	Chapter	Excellent High Priest	Grand Chapter
Cryptic Masonry	Council	Illustrious Master	Grand Council
Chivalric Masonry	Commandery	Eminent Commander	Grand Commandery / Grand Encampment
Scottish Rite 4°-14°	Lodge of Perfection	Venerable Master	Valley / Orient / Supreme Council
Scottish Rite 15°-18°	Chapter of Rose Croix	Wise Master	Valley / Orient / Supreme Council
Scottish Rite 19°-30°	Council of Kadosh	Commander	Valley / Orient / Supreme Council
Scottish Rite 31°-32°	Consistory	Master of Kadosh	Valley / Orient / Supreme Council
Scottish Rite Orient	Orient	Sovereign Grand Inspector General or Deputy	Supreme Council
Scottish Rite Valley	Valley	Deputy Inspector General or Personal Representative to the SGIG	Orient

Scottish Rite organizational language in the supplied Southern Jurisdiction overview follows: Supreme Council -> Orient -> Valley -> Lodge of Perfection, Chapter of Rose Croix, Council of Kadosh, and Consistory, together with authorized clubs and committees. Utah is identified as an Orient, and the Valley of Salt Lake is used as a local example.

Language discipline for future conversations

- Use 'Brother' for a Master Mason and ordinary Scottish Rite address as appropriate; 'Companion' for Royal Arch and Cryptic Masonry; 'Sir Knight' for Commandery; 'Honorable' for KCCH; and 'Illustrious' for the 33° honors described in the source.
- Distinguish the legal relationship of membership from the ceremonial act by which a degree, Order, rank, decoration, or honor is conferred.
- Do not call KCCH a 'degree.' It is an invitational rank, honor, and decoration. Do not call the Grand Cross another degree; it is an honor.
- Do not use 'joined the York Rite' when the precise fact is that a Brother petitioned a Chapter, was elected, and was Advanced, Inducted, Received and Acknowledged, or Exalted according to the particular stage.
- Do not use 'got his Scottish Rite degrees' where precise verbs are available. Use Advanced, Received and Elected, Received and Constituted, Created/Received/Constituted, Anointed and Elevated, Invested, Coroneted, or Bestowed as applicable.
- Use current governing-body terminology when it differs from this working overview; document the variation rather than silently blending systems.

The three-envelope presentation - Utah working practice

About one week after the Brother reaches the model's Member-in-Good-Standing milestone, the Mentor should celebrate the Brother's success and present at least three separately marked envelopes, with petitions prepared as far as legitimately possible so the Brother can review, affirm, sign, and pay the appropriate fees if he chooses:

- 1) Keystone Mark Master Masons Lodge No. 00.
- 2) His local York Rite Bodies: Chapter, Council, and Commandery, subject to all applicable qualifications.
- 3) His local Scottish Rite Valley within the appropriate Orient: Lodge of Perfection, Chapter of Rose Croix, Council of Kadosh, and Consistory.

The presentation should feel celebratory, not transactional. Administrative fields may be prepared in advance, but personal declarations, belief statements, attestations, and choices must remain the Brother's own and should be reviewed and affirmed by him.

The Mentor may have preferences; the mentorship process may not. Inform completely. Represent fairly. Disclose limits. Make introductions. Preserve free choice. Support the Brother's decision.

9. Regularity, Recognition, Masonic Authority, and Organizational Status

Regularity and recognition are separate but allied concepts. Regularity concerns whether a Grand Lodge meets the applicable standards by which another jurisdiction evaluates Masonic legitimacy. Recognition is the sovereign act by which a Grand Lodge acknowledges another Grand Lodge for fraternal relations. A body may not simply recognize itself into amity.

Commission on Information for Recognition - current North American standard

- The Commission was organized in 1951; its Standards for Recognition were adopted in 1952.
- The current three-part standard is: (1) legitimacy of origin; (2) exclusive territorial jurisdiction, except by mutual consent and/or treaty; and (3) adherence to the Ancient Landmarks, specifically belief in God, the Volume of Sacred Law as indispensable Lodge furniture, and prohibition of political and religious discussion in Lodge.
- The Commission investigates and reports. It expressly does not advise or recommend that recognition be granted.
- The final decision to recognize, continue recognition, suspend relations, or withdraw recognition belongs to the sovereign Grand Lodge concerned.
- Recognition status is dynamic. When visitation, affiliation, inter-jurisdictional communication, or credentials depend on recognition, verify the current status rather than relying on an old report.

Do not silently merge different recognition systems

- The North American Commission's three Standards are its own working standard.
- The United Grand Lodge of England's 1929 Basic Principles are a separate eight-point recognition framework and should be attributed to UGLE.
- Mackey, Pound, and other Landmark systems are jurisprudential formulations, not universal Masonic legislation.
- The controlling question for an individual Mason is always what his own sovereign Grand Lodge recognizes, prohibits, permits, and requires.

Phylaxis Society Commission on Bogus Masonry

- The Phylaxis Commission emphasizes documented lineage and lawful Masonic authority, especially in the Prince Hall context through African Lodge No. 459 and recognized English, Irish, or Scottish lines of authority.
- A civil corporation, nonprofit registration, tax status, website, seal, title, patent, familiar ritual, regalia, or self-declared Grand Lodge does not by itself create Masonic authority.
- Similarity of form is not continuity of authority.
- When the Phylaxis Commission classifies a body as bogus, attribute that classification to the Commission rather than presenting the adjective as an unattributed universal judgment.
- A man who was misled into an organization that lacks legitimate Masonic authority is not automatically a bad man. Separate the status of the organization from the man's own knowledge, intent, character, truthfulness, and present qualifications.

Corporate existence answers: 'Does this legal entity exist?' Regularity asks: 'By what Masonic authority does this body exist?' Recognition asks: 'Which sovereign Masonic jurisdictions are in fraternal relations with it?'

Preferred neutral language

When a more specific competent-authority classification is unnecessary, disputed, or unavailable, use the following standing language:

Person: 'a member of an organization that does not meet the basic requirements of the Standards of Regularity/Recognition.'
Organization: 'an organization that does not meet the basic requirements of the Standards of Regularity/Recognition.'

- When possible, identify the actual defect more precisely: origin, practice, territorial standing, or lack of recognition by a named sovereign Grand Lodge.
- Do not use 'clandestine,' 'irregular,' 'unrecognized,' and 'bogus' as automatic synonyms. Their usage varies and should be attributed to the authority applying the term.
- Describe the condition first; attribute the classification second.

Five-question verification model

- Identity - What exactly is the organization claiming to be?
- Authority - From what competent Masonic authority does it claim its Charter, Warrant, or lawful descent?
- Regularity - Does its origin and practice satisfy the standards applied by the relevant jurisdiction?
- Recognition - Does the Mason's own sovereign Grand Lodge currently recognize it and permit Masonic intercourse?
- Personal qualification - If an individual comes from such a body, is he personally worthy, well qualified, properly informed, truthful, and eligible under the controlling Masonic law?

Status changes: suspension, expulsion, and demit

Older Masonic jurisprudence often treats Craft Lodge suspension or expulsion as having downstream consequences for appendant-body membership because appendant bodies require continuing Craft qualification, while an appendant-body penalty does not necessarily erase Craft membership. Likewise, demit, transfer, sojourning status, rights of visitation, appeal, and reinstatement vary materially by jurisdiction. Treat these as Code questions, not universal assumptions.

Fraternity and charitable entities

Freemasonry should be described principally as a fraternity or fraternal order, not merely as 'a charity.' Many Masonic bodies and their charitable foundations are separate legal entities with different tax classifications. Never assume a particular 501(c) status from a body's name; verify the actual entity and current filing when legal or financial accuracy matters.

10. Obedience and Constituted Authority

Classical Masonic jurisprudence strongly emphasizes obedience to constituted authority as a safeguard of order. The working hierarchy is Mason -> Lodge -> Grand Lodge -> the governing Constitution, Regulations, established usages, and whatever the jurisdiction recognizes as fundamental Masonic law.

What obedience means

- Masonic obedience attaches to lawful office and lawful jurisdiction, not to personality, seniority, popularity, title, or decoration.
- A Worshipful Master, Grand Master, Lodge, or Grand Lodge exercises only the authority actually granted by the governing law.
- Older language directing a Mason to 'put his elder to worship' uses 'worship' in the historical sense of honor, dignity, or respect - not religious adoration.
- A Mason may obey a lawful ruling with which he disagrees without surrendering his judgment. Obedience governs conduct; it does not require intellectual servility.

Obedience and appeal are paired principles

- Obedience preserves order.
- Appeal restrains error and abuse.
- The ordinary remedy for an erroneous, improper, or unjust exercise of Masonic authority is the lawful review, grievance, jurisprudence, trial, Grand Master, or Grand Lodge process provided by the controlling Code.
- The exact route of appeal is jurisdiction-specific. Read the Code.

Authority descends through lawful constitution; accountability ascends through lawful appeal.

Boundary of obedience

The older jurisprudential language of 'passive obedience' should not be converted into a universal modern rule that a Mason must knowingly commit an unlawful, fraudulent, dangerous, or professionally unethical act because a Masonic superior ordered it. No Masonic authority can legitimately convert wrongdoing into duty.

- A Masonic order does not authorize lying, perjury, evidence destruction, obstruction of justice, theft, falsification of records, unlawful discrimination, or breach of professional ethics.

- The nine Sacred Duties control the hierarchy: duty to God and Truth, just civil law, and honest vocation stand above Fraternity.
- A Mason obeys because the authority is lawfully constituted - not because the authority is infallible.

11. Truth, justice, law, vocation, and Brotherly obligation

Truth is treated in this framework as a Divine attribute. To be good and true is foundational; integrity, honor, and fidelity depend on honesty and moral conduct. Brotherly Love therefore cannot require a Brother to become dishonest.

Crime and the common conspiracy hypothetical

If an accused Mason encountered a police officer, sheriff, detective, booking officer, prosecutor, defense attorney, bailiff, witness, stenographer, or judge who were also Masons, Masonic Brotherhood would not authorize any of them to lie, commit perjury, suppress or fabricate evidence, obstruct justice, falsify records, violate lawful process, or breach professional ethics.

- Police and investigators: investigate and report truthfully; preserve evidence; follow lawful procedure.
- Prosecutor: seek justice honestly; disclose and handle evidence according to law and professional duty.
- Defense counsel: provide loyal and competent lawful representation and preserve legitimate attorney-client confidentiality, but never lie, fabricate evidence, or assist false testimony.
- Witness: tell the truth subject only to lawful privileges and protections; Masonic fraternity is not itself an evidentiary privilege.
- Court officers and stenographers: maintain accurate process and records.
- Judge: remain impartial and follow recusal/conflict rules where applicable.

Priority test: God and Truth first; Country and just law next; Vocation must be performed honestly; Fraternity is ninth. Brotherhood operates inside those higher duties, never against them.

A Brother accused or convicted of wrongdoing may still receive lawful compassion: humane treatment, help obtaining counsel, appropriate visitation, support for innocent family members, encouragement toward repentance and restitution, and prayer according to faith. Keeping a lawful confidence is not the same as concealing a crime.

12. Historical milestones to remember

Use these dates with precise historical wording. Where a feast-day association is calendrically true but documentary intent has not been established, describe it as an association rather than proof that the date was deliberately selected for that feast.

Date	Milestone	Standing wording / caution
24 June 1717	Premier Grand Lodge in London	UGLE's official history says four London Lodges met on St. John's Day and declared themselves a Grand Lodge. 'Moderns' was a later rival label.
24 June 1725	Grand Lodge of Ireland	First recorded Communication of Grand Lodge. Avoid the anachronistic phrase 'Republic of Ireland Grand Lodge.'
30 November 1736	Grand Lodge of Scotland	Inaugural formation in Edinburgh; the date is St. Andrew's Day. Use the body's formal 'Antient Free and Accepted Masons of Scotland' spelling when precision matters.
17 July 1751	English Antients	Rival English Grand Lodge established. Its long historical styles and Prince Edwin/York language belong to its own constitutional tradition; do not treat the 926 claim as independently proven history.
27 December 1813	United Grand Lodge of England	Union of the Premier/Modern and Antient Grand Lodges on St. John the Evangelist's Day.
16-20 January 1872	Grand Lodge of Utah	The Utah convention met to organize the Grand Lodge of Ancient Free and Accepted Masons of Utah. Current Utah historical material identifies organization in January 1872; surviving accounts place the organizing convention from 16 through 20 January.
20 January 1872	Utah closing milestone	The convention/proceedings culminated at the close of the organizing sessions. The association with St. Sebastian's feast is symbolically notable, but deliberate selection for that feast requires documentary proof.
1896-1897	Utah A.F.&A.M. -> F.&A.M. nomenclature question	Primary Utah material proves early use of 'Ancient Free and Accepted Masons of Utah' and later use of 'Free and Accepted Masons of Utah.' The claim that a clerical/misfiling error caused the permanent change remains an archival hypothesis until established by the original proceedings.

13. Standing structure for future conversations

Recruitment and public education

- Profane and Inquirer: educate and inform; never manufacture desire or ask them to join.
- Aspirant: once desire is self-expressed, begin mutual discernment and appropriate preliminary inquiry.
- Petitioner: formal request triggers lawful investigation, recommendation, and ballot; no guarantee of acceptance.
- Appender/Rites education: begin at Fellow Craft; actionable petitions come only after eligibility and preparation.

Educational standard

- Always distinguish documented history, etymology, current jurisdictional law, common tradition, interpretation, and speculation.
- Use primary or governing-body sources when exact eligibility, timing, law, or current practice matters.
- Do not overstate uncertain etymologies, especially Mason.
- Do not treat memorization as education. Aim for symbolic, historical, pragmatic, philosophical, moral, and spiritual understanding.
- A proficiency demonstrates sufficient progress for the next stage; it is not a declaration of complete mastery.

Mentorship standard

- Know the Candidate well enough to match him intelligently with a compatible Coach/Mentor.
- Support his faith without sectarian coercion.
- Expose him to the wider Masonic landscape early enough to make later decisions informed.
- Represent York Rite, Scottish Rite, and other appropriate opportunities without bias - especially when the Mentor does not belong to them.
- Never make the Brother's Masonic decisions for him.
- The long-term goal is to turn the instructed into an instructor, the guided into a guide, and the mentored into a mentor.

The process does not end when a man becomes a Master Mason. That is where the mentored Masonic journey properly begins.

14. One-page quick reference

Phase	Status	Rule
Public	Profane -> Inquirer	Inform. Answer. Do not solicit.
Interest	Aspirant	Mutual discernment; 6-18 months in the working model.
Formal request	Petitioner	Investigate impartially; about 2-4 months; read, report, ballot.
Selection	Elect	Prepare lawfully and deliberately.
Formation	Candidate -> EA -> proficiency -> FC -> proficiency -> MM -> proficiency	Coach teaches; Mentor guides; minimum intervals and readiness apply.
Broader orientation	Begins at Fellow Craft	Explain York Rite and Scottish Rite fairly and early.
Good standing	MM + required proficiency + support + dues, per working definition	About one week later, Mentor presents the three Utah opportunity envelopes.
Lifetime	Mentored Masonic Journey	Learn, serve, lead, choose freely, and eventually mentor others.
Precise body language	Lodge / Chapter / Council / Commandery / Scottish Rite bodies	Use exact ceremonial verbs, resulting status, style of address, and governing-body terminology; do not flatten all progression into 'joined' or 'got a degree.'
Membership language	Petition / election / initiation / advancement / affiliation / status	Use the exact act and status. Eligibility is not entitlement; fees and dues do not purchase advancement.
Regularity / Recognition	Grand Lodge and organizational legitimacy	Verify identity, authority, regularity, territorial standing, and current recognition. Attribute formal classifications.

Phase	Status	Rule
Obedience	Constituted Masonic authority	Obey lawful authority; appeal through the Code; never commit wrongdoing on Masonic command.
Historical claims	Grand Lodge milestones	Use official/primary history where possible and label feast-day symbolism or archival hypotheses as such.

Core formulas

- Freemasonry informs; the individual chooses.
- Guard legitimate thresholds; do not create arbitrary barriers.
- Teach for understanding, not mere recitation.
- Educate early. Qualify properly. Decide freely. Proceed deliberately.
- The Lodge teaches the symbol; the Brother's faith interprets the theology.
- The Mentor may have preferences; the mentorship process may not.
- Brotherly Love requires lawful support, never dishonesty.
- Masonic improvement is comparative inwardly, not competitive outwardly.
- Precision in language protects precision in meaning: petition, election, degree, Order, rank, decoration, honor, style, and governing body are not interchangeable.
- Regularity is not recognition; recognition is not self-declared.
- Similarity of form is not continuity of authority.
- Describe the condition first; attribute the classification second.
- Corporate existence does not create Masonic authority.
- Authority descends through lawful constitution; accountability ascends through lawful appeal.
- A Mason obeys because authority is constituted, not because authority is infallible.

Source base and authority notes

This charter synthesizes the conversation, user-supplied materials, and current verification sources listed below. The Overview of the main journey of Freemasonry remains the standing working reference for precise body-specific progression verbs, styles of address, and organizational language. The Commission on Information for Recognition and the Phylaxis Society Commission on Bogus Masonry are now standing references for regularity/recognition and lineage questions. These materials inform the working model but do not replace the current law of the competent sovereign Grand Lodge or appendant governing body.

ID	Source	Used for
S1	Ideal Onboarding Process (46 pages)	Aspirant/Petitioner/Candidate periods; investigation workflow; mentoring; degree/proficiency pathway; JotForm intake.
S2	The Personal Interview (9 pages)	Membership expectations, free-will emphasis, petitioner education, investigation suggestions, duties to God/country/community/family, fees/timing examples.
S3	G.A.O.T.U. / Great Architect of the Universe (3 pages)	Architect/Artificer as allegorical titles for Deity; Freemasonry and religion; Volume of Sacred Law.
S4	Supreme Being - encyclopedia excerpt	Creator, worship, classical theism, philosophical arguments and objections, plural religious usage.
S5	Church of Satan Frequently Asked Questions (45 pages)	Primary-source organizational statements that Church of Satan / LaVeyan Satanism is atheistic and rejects supernatural deity.
S6	Light not Lucifer (38 pages)	Christian 'Light of the World' material; Hebrew hehel / Latin lucifer discussion; distinction between light symbolism and later Lucifer-as-Satan usage.
S7	User-supplied public-post material and discussion	Working claims and formulations concerning belief, Fatherhood of God/Brotherhood of Man, Masonic Light, anti-Masonic conspiracy responses, and religious qualification.
S8	Overview of the main journey of Freemasonry (10 pages)	Precise verbs of progression; member styles; Lodge/Chapter/Council/Commandery structure; Scottish Rite bodies, honors, presiding titles, and Supreme Council -> Orient -> Valley governance.
S9	Regularity Versus Recognition (12 pages)	Early working compilation on regularity, recognition, clandestine/irregular vocabulary, expulsion/demit, and fraternity-versus-charity questions. Use with jurisdictional and source-quality cautions.
S10	Regularity and Recognition: The Twin Pillars of Masonic Legitimacy (18 pages)	Research paper refining the distinction between regularity and recognition; Part II supersedes Part I and flags unresolved or source-dependent claims.
S11	Commission on Information for Recognition - current site and	Current North American Standards for Recognition;

ID	Source	Used for
	Resources	Commission role; UGLE 1929 Basic Principles; historical reports. Verified 16 Aug. 2026.
S12	Phylaxis Society - Commission on Bogus Masonry	Lineage-based authority analysis, bogus-body classifications, educational treatment of men misled by such bodies, and court/history resources. Verified 16 Aug. 2026.
S13	Official Grand Lodge historical sources	UGLE, Grand Lodge of Ireland, Grand Lodge of Scotland, and Grand Lodge of Utah materials used to refine the historical chronology and terminology.

Authority hierarchy for future answers

- 1) Current governing Masonic law and official body requirements when a jurisdiction-specific rule is at issue.
- 2) Primary historical documents for historical claims.
- 3) Official organizational sources for what an outside group says it believes.
- 4) Reliable scholarship for interpretation, classification, and contested history.
- 5) Common Masonic tradition and the user's working framework, clearly labeled as such.
- 6) Symbolic or philosophical interpretation, expressly identified as interpretation rather than fact.

Final caution: This framework is designed to guide our conversations and educational work. It is not an official publication of a Grand Lodge, Grand Chapter, Grand Council, Grand Commandery, Scottish Rite Supreme Council, Valley, or Orient. Exact laws, membership qualifications, ritual rules, time limits, good-standing definitions, and appendant-body eligibility should be verified with the competent current authority before publication or implementation.

Current-status rule: Recognition, amity, Grand Lodge law, appendant-body eligibility, disciplinary consequences, and tax/entity status can change. Before publication or action, verify the present competent authority rather than relying on a historical snapshot.